

2 GOP hopefuls ahead in race for governor

Crowded field of Democrats leads to confounding rankings in primary campaign.

By Seema Mehta

Despite a long, entrenched Democratic reign over California politics, a new poll shows two Republicans leading by slim margins in the state's 2026 race for governor as the June primary election fast approaches.

The confounding results appear to be mostly due to the state's left-leaning electorate feeling uninspired by any single candidate in the crowded field of eight top Democrats. Because of California's top-two primary rule, that lethargy could lead to Democrats being shut out of a November election that will determine the next leader of the largest state in the union, though that is still considered unlikely.

Conservative commentator Steve Hilton had the support of 17% of likely voters and Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco had the backing of 16%, according to a poll released Wednesday by UC Berkeley's Institute of Governmental Studies and co-sponsored by The Times.

Following closely behind were Democrats Rep. Eric Swalwell of Northern California and former Orange County Rep. Katie Porter, both of whom had support from 13% of the likely voters surveyed. Aside from billionaire hedge fund founder and environmental activist Tom Steyer, who registered at 10% support after plowing tens of millions of dollars into his campaign, no other Democrat had won support from more than 5% of likely voters, the poll showed.

Mark DiCamillo, director of the poll, said he was stunned by how fractured voters are and how little knowledge they have about the candidates less than 60 days before ballots start arriving in Californians' mailboxes.

"This is historic for me, and especially given that none of the candidates have really a positive image rating with voters, also startling. I mean, perhaps one of the reasons why voters are disengaged, they're just not enthusiastic about any of the candidates," he said. "They're kind of sleepwalking to this election."

Swalwell and Porter both hew toward the progressive wing of the party and rose to national prominence as frequent guests on cable news shows and as combative, at times theatrical, committee members during congress.

Democrats target state's gas tax

Two candidates in governor's race say cash-strapped families need a break. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Affordability is the top concern across party lines

These are the priorities that likely voters feel the next governor should address

Priorities	Total	Democrats	Republicans	Other/No party
Reducing the cost of living in California	40%	44%	34%	40%
Cutting waste, fraud and political corruption	25%	10%	48%	27%
Homelessness	13%	16%	9%	12%
Building more affordable housing	12%	18%	2%	12%
Crime and public safety	12%	6%	22%	11%
Education and the public schools	12%	16%	5%	10%
Protecting immigrant communities	11%	17%	1%	11%
Balancing the state budget	11%	9%	13%	10%
Cutting taxes	10%	4%	21%	8%
Protecting the environment	10%	16%	1%	10%
Lowering the state's high gasoline prices	10%	5%	19%	10%
Reducing healthcare costs	7%	11%	2%	6%
Promoting clean energy sources	5%	7%	Less than 1%	5%
Job creation	5%	6%	2%	4%
Reforming the state's homeowners insurance market	5%	5%	4%	6%
Reducing the size of state government	4%	1%	11%	5%
Reducing energy utility rates	4%	6%	3%	7%

Berkeley IGS Poll conducted online March 9-14, 2026, among over 5,000 registered voters, 3,889 of whom are considered likely to vote in the June California primary.

Berkeley IGS poll

HANNA SENDER Los Angeles Times

‘Profoundly shocking’ Chavez allegations



Los Angeles Times

UFW cited allegations against Cesar Chavez involving “abuse of young women or minors.”

By Karen Garcia, Gustavo Arellano and Richard Winton

The United Farm Workers union said it will not participate in celebrations of its founder Cesar Chavez amid what the union described as “troubling allegations” against the iconic Chicano figure.

The union, in a statement released Tuesday, did not detail the accusations against Chavez but said they were concerning enough for the organization to take action. But several events around the country honoring Chavez, including those in San Bernardino, Tucson, Houston, San Antonio and Corpus Christi, Texas, have been canceled in recent weeks, with little explanation given by organizers.

[See Chavez, A6]

Returning lands to tribes’ care

State to put millions of acres under Indigenous stewardship

By Noah Haggerty

California unveiled a plan Tuesday to bring at least 7.5 million acres of land and coastal waters under the care of Indigenous tribes.

That number represents roughly 7% of the state's land and waters. It also corresponds with the amount of land the federal government promised it would hold as reservations for Indigenous tribes after California joined

the union in 1850. Congress ultimately rejected these treaties in a secret meeting — after pressure from the state — and failed to notify tribes, many of which upheld their end of the agreement to relocate.

The new policy, set by the California Natural Resources Agency, aims to start healing the harm caused by the state's actions to bar tribes from their homelands and criminalize their cultural and land man-

agement practices. These actions not only harmed Native communities, whose cultures and ways of life are intimately tied to the plants, animals and landscape of their homelands, but also caused well-documented harm to ecosystems through the loss of biodiversity, takeover of invasive species, degradation of water quality and increase in wildfire risk.

“Tribal stewardship is so critical for all of us ... the na-

[See Policy, A8]

Counterterrorism chief steps down over war in Iran

Israeli pressure, he says, led Trump into conflict that serves no benefit to Americans.

By Ana Ceballos and Kevin Rector

WASHINGTON — Joe Kent, the director of the National Counterterrorism Center, abruptly resigned Tuesday, becoming the most senior national security official to break publicly with the Trump administration over its military campaign against Iran.

In a statement posted on social media, Kent said he “cannot in good conscience” continue serving in the administration, contending that Iran had “posed no imminent threat to our nation” and that the United States had been drawn into the conflict through “pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby.”

“I cannot support sending the next generation off to fight and die in a war that serves no benefit to the American people nor justifies the cost of American lives,” Kent wrote in a letter addressed to President Trump. “I pray that you will reflect upon what we are doing in Iran, and who we are doing it for.”

Speaking in the Oval Office, Trump dismissed



Jenny Kane Associated Press

JOE KENT, a Trump appointee, said that Iran was not an “imminent threat” to the U.S.

Kent's concerns, telling reporters that he had long believed the counterterrorism director — whom he nominated to the post in February 2025 — was “very weak on security.” The president insisted that Iran has been a threat to the U.S. “for a long time,” and said that it was a “good thing” Kent is leaving.

The resignation came at an uncertain moment for the administration. The war, which has repeatedly been sold to Americans as “short term” and contained, is now in its third week, with fraying alliances, renewed missile and drone fire on gulf Arab nations from Iran, new Israeli strikes on Iran and Lebanon, mounting casualties and no clear exit strategy.

“If we left right now it would take 10 years for them to rebuild,” Trump told re-

[See Kent, A4]

There’s no rush to drill in California

Even as oil prices soar, state's aging fields and market volatility make companies hesitant.

By Blanca Begert

If you are an oil producer with wells in California and global oil prices have risen to over \$100 a barrel in the last week, are you going to drill new wells?

It's a question that touches the lives of hundreds of thousands of Californians who either live near oil wells or receive royalty checks as mineral rights owners.

Experts said probably not, given this state's aging fields and the unpredictability of global prices.

It's too early for data that will show whether companies have ordered more

drilling rigs on their fields — known as the rig count — since the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran and sent oil prices soaring. But analysts and producers say only if prices stay above \$80 for at least a year do they expect an increase in drilling.

“Nobody expects today's high prices to last and we could very likely get back to the low \$60 [per barrel] environment we faced just a few weeks ago,” said Rock Zierman, chief executive of the California Independent Petroleum Assn. trade group.

Experts say the unique geology of California's fields, and the nature of its heavy crude, make new projects, and efforts to pump more oil out of existing ones, costlier and more energy-intensive than drilling in other parts of the country.

In the Permian basin of

[See Drilling, A11]



Justin Sullivan Getty Images

THE TRUMP administration has ordered the resumption of oil production off California's coast.

A push to rein in legal industry’s ‘bad actors’

Trial lawyers support state bills on illegal client solicitation and litigation investors.

By Rebecca Ellis

A group of California trial lawyers is backing a package of bills aimed at policing their industry by ramping up the penalties for attorneys who recruit clients illegally or prioritize the desires of hedge fund investors.

The Consumer Attorneys of California, a prominent

trade group, said it is supporting two bills this legislative session meant to crack down on the “small number of bad actors engaged in illegal conduct that threatens to undermine public trust” in the state's legal bar.

The group said the bills, introduced Monday by Assemblymembers Ash Kalra (D-San José) and Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Los Angeles), were a response to recent Times investigations involving California lawyers. The Times found nine clients within L.A. County's \$4-billion sex-abuse settlement who said they were

paid to sue and, in some cases, fabricate claims that became part of the historic payout. Another story examined opaque investor financing arrangements used by some firms.

“We're not trying to insulate ourselves from accountability,” said Douglas Saeltzer, president of the attorney group, in an interview. “There needs to be consequences.”

The bill introduced by Zbur would disbar any attorney who is convicted of illegally soliciting clients. Kalra's bill would ban private equity firms and hedge

funds from dictating case strategy after giving money to a law firm.

Plaintiff's attorneys say the legislative push is an attempt to clean up their profession's image. It comes amid efforts by companies and governments frequently targeted by lawsuits to rein in a barrage of litigation.

Uber is pushing a measure for the November ballot that would limit how much lawyers can collect in fees for car crash cases, encouraging Californians to “stop the billboard lawyer scam.” A coalition of California

[See Lawyers, A6]

No cause seen for Pendleton blast

A report on the Oct. 18 detonation over the 5 Freeway says the malfunction was “one in a million.” **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Airfares likely to rise with fuel cost

As summer travel approaches, airlines expect to pass along higher prices to passengers. **BUSINESS, A9**

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NFL teams are living on the edge

Sam Farmer predicts early run on edge rushers in his first mock draft. **SPORTS, B10**

L.A. Phil has not lost its ambition

As Dudamel moves on, the orchestra plans a bold 2026-27 season. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Very hot.
L.A. Basin: 98/64. **B6**

